

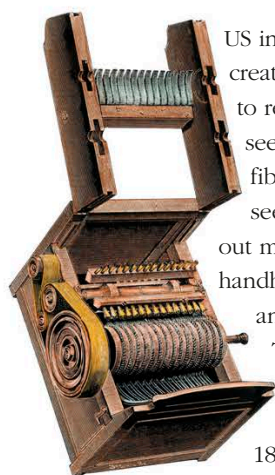
Inventions of the Industrial Age

The Industrial Revolution (1760–1840) was a period of great innovation as groundbreaking technologies and inventions transformed the way humans lived and worked. Not all these new machines improved the lives of ordinary workers—some required operators to labor for long hours in dangerous conditions. But others, such as the automobile, offered a glimpse of a new freedom.

Seed separator

Cotton gin

Where US
When 1793



US inventor Eli Whitney created the cotton gin to remove unwanted seeds from cotton fibers. Before this, the seeds were picked out manually or with handheld rollers, a slow and laborious process. This made large-scale cotton production possible, and by 1850 it had become the US's main export.

But since most cotton workers were enslaved Black people, it guaranteed them a life of backbreaking drudgery.

Automatic pattern weaver

Jacquard loom

Where France
When 1804

Named after its French inventor Joseph Marie Jacquard, the Jacquard loom pioneered the mass production of woven patterned cloth. Previously, skilled workers wove patterns into cloth by adjusting threads by hand. Now anyone could change the threads simply by following instructions from cards punched with holes.



Mechanical reaper

McCormick Reaper

Where US
When 1831

US inventor Cyrus McCormick designed a horse-drawn mechanical reaping machine. A rotating wheel pulled and cut the crops, which then dropped into the fields ready for collection. Crops could now be harvested quicker than ever before using fewer farmhands to help.